



This season, too, the franchise continued this trend.

In the first round, the Celtics faced the Miami Heat. In the best-of-seven series, the Celtics wrapped things up 4-1, comfortably cruising to the Conference semifinals, where it defeated the Cleveland Cavaliers with the same 4-1 scoreline. It then swept the Indiana Pacers 4-0 in the Conference finals.

In the NBA Finals, the Celtics met the Dallas Mavericks for the first time in the competition's history. Despite Dallas being armed with

Luka Dončić — the Slovenian forward-guard who was a contender for the MVP award with a points-per-game average of 33.9 — Boston extended Dallas' wait for a second NBA title.

#### **Lacklustre Lakers and not-so-golden Warriors**

During the late '90s to late 2000s, the Los Angeles Lakers, led by legends Shaquille O'Neal and Kobe Bryant, celebrated five title-winning seasons.

However, following O'Neal's retirement in 2011 and during

**Deserved winners:** This marked the seventh time that Boston Celtics lifted the Larry O'Brien Championship trophy after topping both the Atlantic Division and the Eastern Conference.

AFP

Bryant's final years, the Lakers failed to qualify for the Playoffs for six straight seasons.

Its fortunes changed with the signing of LeBron James, whose 2019-20 season not only helped his team lift the trophy after a decade but also earned him the MVP title. However, things have been quiet since then.

After failing to make it past the first round in the 2020-21 season, the Lakers didn't qualify for the Playoffs the following year. There was a slight improvement in the 2022-23 season when the Lakers reached the Conference finals, but they faced another first-round exit this past season.

Perhaps the promise of the first-ever father-son duo in NBA



**Defending champion Denver Nuggets, which knocked out the Lakers this time around, was ousted by the Minnesota Timberwolves in the Conference semifinals.**